

Standing Up the Runner

What the self-hosted runner actually is on disk, the user-isolation decision behind it, and the four-phase install. Verification appended once each phase is confirmed run.

host: clubuntu.dala-cirius.ts.net 2026-08-16

01 The decision: a dedicated user, not katlego

`katlego` already has everything technically needed — docker-group membership, ownership of the deploy directory. Using it would've meant zero new setup. Chose the more isolated path instead, on purpose.

NOT CHOSEN — run as katlego

```
groups: katlego, sudo, docker, users
      zero new setup
      but a compromised job now sits in an
      account that's one password away from root
```

CHOSEN — dedicated ghrunner

```
groups: ghrunner, docker, katlego*
      no sudo, no login shell
      *katlego group added only to bridge
      write access to the deploy directory
```

The blast radius of anything a queued job does is now "can control Docker, can write to one specific directory" — not "can do anything katlego can, including sudo."

02 What the runner actually is, on disk

Not a system service that already exists — a plain directory of files, downloaded once, that GitHub's Actions backend and a small local agent both know how to talk to.

/opt/actions-runner (home of ghrunner)

bin/, externals/
the agent software itself

.runner, .credentials
which repo, which labels, registered identity

_work/
fresh checkout, per job – disposable

svc.sh
installs/starts it as a systemd service

once running as a service, it polls GitHub continuously –
the same poll-not-push behavior documented in the Deployment series

`.runner` is the file that makes label matching work — it's where `clubuntu` gets recorded as a label this specific install answers to, which is why `--labels clubuntu` at config time isn't optional.

03 The four phases

PHASE 1 – USER, DOCKER ACCESS, BRIDGE TO THE DEPLOY DIRECTORY

```
sudo useradd --system --create-home --home-dir /opt/actions-runner --shell /usr/sbin/nologin g
sudo usermod -aG docker ghrunner
sudo usermod -aG katlego ghrunner
sudo chmod -R g+rwX /opt/docker/manpage
sudo chmod g+s /opt/docker/manpage /opt/docker/manpage/db
```

PHASE 3 – CONFIGURE, AS GHRUNNER, WITH THE REQUIRED LABEL

```
sudo -u ghrunner -i
cd /opt/actions-runner
# GitHub's download + extract commands go here, unmodified
./config.sh --url https://github.com/kat-e8/manpage --token <TOKEN> \
  --name clubuntu --labels clubuntu --unattended
exit
```

PHASE 4 – INSTALL AS A SYSTEMD SERVICE

```
cd /opt/actions-runner
sudo ./svc.sh install ghrunner
sudo ./svc.sh start
sudo ./svc.sh status
```

Phase 2 — generating the registration token — happens entirely in GitHub's web UI (repo Settings → Actions → Runners → New self-hosted runner) and isn't a command to log.

04 Status

PHASE	STATUS
1 — user + permissions	<i>pending confirmation</i>
2 — registration token	<i>pending confirmation</i>
3 — configure with label	<i>pending confirmation</i>
4 — systemd service	<i>pending confirmation</i>

This section gets replaced with actual verification output once each phase is confirmed — the same pattern as every other execution-log entry in this folder.

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